	MANAGEMENT OF NON-CONFORMING WORK	
	Document no: ASMF7.17	
Compiled by:	**Sifiso Nyambi - Laboratory Manager**	
Approved by:	**Nonhlanhla Msibi - Operations Manager**	

Table of Contents

1. Purpose 2
2. Scope 2
3. Responsibilities 2
4. Identification of non-conformity 3
5. Initial Actions 4
6. Documentation 4
7. Corrective Actions 5
8. Follow-Up and Closure 5
9. Timelines 6
10. Record Retention 6
11. Revision 7

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1. Purpose

To define the procedure for identifying, documenting, evaluating, correcting, and preventing recurrence of any non-conforming work (NCW) that could affect the quality, integrity, or validity of certified reference materials (CRMs) or candidate RMs. This also extends to the testing section of the lab (ISO 17025, sampling, testing, ensuring the validity of results, and reporting).

2. Scope

This applies to:

- Testing, PT and RM/CRM batches failing stability or homogeneity requirement
- Incorrect property value assignments or uncertainty estimations
- Equipment malfunction affecting measurement validity
- Labelling, packaging, or CoA errors
- Any deviation from production or testing procedures
- Incorrect traceability or documentation
- All requirements associated with ISO 17025.

3. Responsibilities

Role	Responsibility
Lab Manager	Authorize containment and initiate investigation
Lab Supervisor	Lead root cause analysis and maintain NCW register Close non-conformances and perform follow-up
Lab analyst/ operator	Report and document non-conforming work immediately
Operations Manager	Perform the follow-up process in its entirety

4. Identification of non-conformity

Major Nonconformance

A major nonconformance is a significant failure that affects the reliability, validity, or integrity of results or indicates a breakdown of the quality management system.

Key Characteristics

- Direct impact on test/calibration results
- Evidence of systemic failure (not isolated)
- Non-compliance with critical ISO requirements
- Results may be invalid or unreliable
- Requires immediate corrective action

Minor Nonconformance

A minor nonconformance is a deviation that does not significantly affect the validity of results and is typically isolated or administrative in nature.

Key Characteristics

- No immediate impact on **result accuracy**
- **Isolated incident**, not systemic
- Does not compromise **overall system effectiveness**
- Still requires correction, but not urgent escalation

Sources may include but not limited to:

- Observation during routine preparation, or testing work, or supervision
- Internal audits
- Stability/homogeneity test failures
- Customer complaints
- Out-of-spec test results
- Incorrect CoA's or labelling errors

5. Initial Actions

- Immediately halt use of the affected PT, RM/CRM, or analysis or process step.
- Label the product or isolate the equipment with "NON-CONFORMING" tags.
- Notify Management.
- Use SANAS F03-09 non-conformance, corrective action, and clearance report form, root cause analysis form AS001MF, AS004MF, Brainstorming form to document the process of non-conforming work, and AS009MF for additional space (ONLY USED WHERE NECESSARY).

6. Documentation

The process of opening, processing and closing a non-conformance shall document the following:

- SANAS F03-09, which documents the following:
  - Date of detection
  - Unique NCW ID
  - Area /scope assessed/affected
  - Responsible person & assessor
  - Detailed observation of the non-conformance
  - Root cause analysis linked to form AS004MF
  - Corrective action taken, Corrective action verified/cleared and follow up on next assessment.
  - Given the NCW rises from a customer complaint, the lab shall send an acknowledgement email.

ADDED:

- Root cause analysis form (AS001MF)
- Brainstorming form (AS004MF)
- Evidence of implementation
- Additional Space for NC's (AS009MF)

7. Corrective Actions

- Where necessary, changes to the management system (procedures, work instructions, risk registers, or controls) shall be implemented to prevent recurrence of the non-conformance.
- Appropriate corrective actions shall be proportional to the risk and impact of the non-conforming work (which will be determined when there is recurrence of NC and/or during internal audits).
- All corrective actions shall be traceable to the identified root cause.

Where necessary:

- Ensure notification of customers and recall CRM's/RM's and certificates and documentation within an appropriate period. This also means that any tested samples which can have a significant impact on the operations of customers shall be relayed to the client.
- PT & COA's reports already sent to participants are recalled or disregarded following the correct amendment process defined in procedure 7.8 Reporting of results.

8. Follow-Up and Closure

Upon closure of the non-conformances and taking into consideration the nature of the non-conformance(major or minor) which informs of the duration of the follow up, the follow-up on the non-conformances will include a review of the effectiveness of actions to address the NCW and if within the specified time frame a recurrence happens, then management has to perform a risk analysis of the non-conformance using document 8.5 Actions to address risks & opportunities.

Management reserves the right to perform an immediate risk assessment for any NC deemed to be of high impact and needing immediate assessment.

- Verify the corrective action eliminated or mitigated the issue
- Retest or recharacterize RM/CRM/sample batch if necessary
- Update NCW register and archive all records securely

9. Timelines

- Major NCs shall be addressed within 7 days from the time of detection.
- Minor NCs shall be addressed within 7-14 days from the time of detection.

ADDED:

- Effectiveness of corrective actions for **Major NCs** shall be reviewed within **1 to 3 months (monitoring period)**, depending on the nature and risk of the non-conformance.
- Effectiveness of corrective actions for **Minor NCs** shall be reviewed within **3 to 6 months (monitoring period)** after implementation.
- Where justified by the nature of the non-conformance (e.g. long-term stability, trend monitoring), extended review periods may be defined and documented.

10. Record Retention

- NCW records must be stored for a minimum of 10 years, linked to batch records.
- Include them in management review for trend analysis.

ADDED
Corrective action records shall be available for verification during internal audits and external assessments.

11. Revision

Revision no	Content changed	Reason for the change	Date
01	Extended the scope of this procedure to ISO 17025, under PURPOSE, SCOPE	Lab expanding to ISO 17025	02/02/2026
02	Update the timelines for the closing of NCs.	NC raised by SANAS	06/02/2026
03	No content changed, just additions to address SANAS findings. (Please see sections 6,8,9,10,11 for the updates- look for "added" subheadings).	To address NC's raised by SANAS.	11/02/2026
04	Notification of NCW reported to lab/operations manager.	• Management is equally responsible for investigating, correcting & closing NCW.	09-16/04/2026
04	No change, only additions.	Added section 8 follow-up and closure process.	
04	Responsibilities of the lab supervisor & Lab manager	Merged the responsibilities between the two positions.	
04	Responsibilities of Operations Manager	Perform the follow-up process on non-conformances	
04	Section 6 has been updated to be clear on the documents used to clear non-conformances raised.	Section 6 proved ambiguous regarding the listed documents, causing confusion during audits.	
04	No changes, added the following clause, "Management reserves the right to perform an	Revised to implement risk based approach for NC evaluation, incorporating a severity-based override for	

	immediate risk assessment for any NC deemed to be of high impact and needing immediate assessment."	immediate assessment of critical risks.	
04	No changes, only addition of a table of contents	Ease of document reading	
04	Removed the introductory application paragraph	Repeatition as the scope also describes where this document applies in the system.	